

Nāṭyaśāstra Gurukulam

A Centre for Civilisational Statecraft

✦ RASA REFLECTIONS • No. 2 ✦

From Examinations to Education

*A Nāṭyaśāstra Reflection on
Human Flourishing*



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RASA REFLECTIONS

An Essay Series from Nāṭyaśāstra Gurukulam



ABOUT THE SERIES

Rasa Reflections is an essay series published by Nāṭyaśāstra Gurukulam: A Centre for Civilisational Statecraft, exploring contemporary questions in education, leadership, ethics, governance and public life through the civilisational wisdom of the Nāṭyaśāstra and India's aesthetic traditions.

Rather than treating aesthetics as a specialised domain of artistic practice, the series approaches rasa as a mode of human formation that refines perception, deepens ethical discernment and contributes to the flourishing of individuals, institutions and civilisation.

Each reflection begins with a contemporary question and journeys towards enduring principles, demonstrating how India's aesthetic knowledge traditions continue to illuminate the challenges of modern public life.



ABOUT THIS PUBLICATION

From Examinations to Education: A Nāṭyaśāstra Reflection on Human Flourishing is the second publication in the Rasa Reflections series.

The reflections presented in this essay are intended to encourage thoughtful dialogue on the contemporary relevance of the Nāṭyaśāstra and the broader Indian aesthetic tradition.



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From Examinations to Education

A Nāṭyaśāstra Reflection on Human Flourishing



सत्यं वद । धर्मं चर ।



Speak the truth. Practise Dharma.

— Taittirīya Upaniṣad (Śikṣāvallī 1.11.1)



From Examinations to Education A Nāṭyaśāstra Reflection on Human Flourishing

The ongoing agitations have exposed more than administrative failure. They have revealed a deeper uncertainty about what education itself is for.

The student protests sweeping the country over paper leaks and recruitment irregularities have forced an uncomfortable truth into the open: a nation that cannot guarantee fairness in its examinations cannot expect confidence in its public institutions. The demand for transparent recruitment and procedural integrity is therefore both legitimate and long overdue. Yet, if this moment is to become a genuine turning point rather than another cycle of public outrage followed by administrative patchwork, India must resist confusing symptoms with causes.

The immediate concerns of examination integrity and fair recruitment undoubtedly demand urgent reform. Yet procedural improvements alone cannot resolve the deeper challenge before us. The crisis is not merely that competitive examinations have become vulnerable to corruption, but that they have come to occupy an overwhelming, almost existential place in national life.

Public discussion remains confined to downstream questions: How do we secure papers? How do we prevent leaks? How do we audit recruitment agencies?

These are necessary questions, but they are not the first questions. The first question is far more fundamental: **What kind of human beings should education cultivate?**

Every civilisation answers this question differently. Its answer determines not merely the structure of its schools and universities, but also its understanding of merit, work, citizenship and human flourishing. Educational procedures are never philosophically neutral. Curricula embody particular conceptions of knowledge. Examinations reveal assumptions about the human person. Recruitment systems presuppose an understanding of the purpose of work. Procedures cannot transcend the philosophy from which they arise.

Every society expects education to equip its young with the knowledge and skills necessary for livelihood. Yet the Indian civilisational tradition has consistently regarded this as only one dimension of education. Its higher purpose is the cultivation of the human being: the awakening of character, discernment, purpose, self-actualisation, and ultimately, transcendence.

Modern India has, almost imperceptibly, come to regard education primarily as a mechanism for securing livelihood through credentialled competition. Schools accumulate marks, universities confer degrees, and examinations allocate opportunities. Educational success is measured by placements, salaries and cut-off scores. Over time, education ceases to be the cultivation of human capability and becomes instead the allocation of scarce opportunity.

Learning becomes secondary to selection. Schools cease to be places where young minds discover themselves and increasingly become mechanisms through which society rations access to livelihood.

The consequences are neither accidental nor surprising. When millions of young people compete for a few thousand desirable positions, and when livelihood, dignity and social mobility depend predominantly upon success in a handful of competitive examinations, those examinations inevitably cease to be academic exercises. They become contests for survival. In such an environment, influence becomes currency, patronage becomes an asset, and the temptation to manipulate procedures grows in direct proportion to the consequences of failure. Paper leaks, nepotism and recruitment scandals are therefore not merely failures of administration. They are symptoms of an educational order organised around dependence upon externally allocated opportunity.

This is why a philosophically impoverished educational system cannot be permanently repaired by stronger surveillance, harsher penalties or more sophisticated anti-cheating technology. Such measures may restrain individual acts of misconduct, but they cannot eliminate the institutional incentives that continually reproduce them. A system whose organising principle is dependence will inevitably encourage the search for gatekeepers.

Institutions cannot remain trustworthy when the philosophy that animates them continually reproduces insecurity.

The *Bhāratīya* knowledge tradition begins not with examinations, but with a different question altogether: What does it mean to become fully human? It is to this question that we must now return.

Education as Liberation

The Indian civilisational tradition approached the question of education from an altogether different premise. Its celebrated definition is at once simple and profound:

सा विद्या या विमुक्तये¹

True knowledge is that which liberates.

This is not a poetic aspiration. It is a philosophical definition of education itself.

The question, then, is: *What does education liberate us from?*

India's modern educational thinkers offered different yet remarkably convergent answers. Mahatma Gandhi saw education as the formation of character through meaningful work and service. Gurudev Tagore envisioned it as the flowering of freedom and creativity. Svami Vivekananda described education as the manifestation of the perfection already within, while Sri Aurobindo understood it as the evolution of consciousness. Svami Sivananda reminded us that genuine learning is inseparable from self-discipline and selfless service. Though differing in emphasis, each affirmed that education is fundamentally concerned with the formation of the human being rather than the accumulation of credentials.

This vision never stood in opposition to scientific or professional excellence. Rather, it nurtured precisely the qualities that enabled pioneers such as Jagadish Chandra Bose, C. V. Raman and Sir M. Visvesvaraya to unite intellectual distinction with service to society. Inner development and worldly achievement were understood not as competing aspirations, but as mutually reinforcing dimensions of a fulfilled life.

Freedom, however, is often misunderstood. It is neither freedom from work nor freedom from responsibility. It is freedom from dependence as the organising principle of one's life. A liberated individual is capable of discovering *svadharma*, that unique mode of contribution through which one's capacities find fulfilment in the service of society. Livelihood is not diminished in such a vision; it is restored to its rightful place as the natural consequence of creating value rather than the primary object of education.

Education understood as liberation does not produce uniformity; it enables vocation. It allows individuals to discover their distinctive gifts, to cultivate a life animated by purpose and sustained by vision, and to realise their *svadharma* through meaningful service to society. Few modern lives illustrate this more vividly than that of Srinivasa Ramanujan. Largely unconstrained by conventional academic pathways, he pursued mathematics with an intensity born not of credentialism but of inner calling. His life reminds us that the highest purpose of education is not merely to certify competence, but to recognise, nurture and liberate the unique possibilities within every individual. Such education prepares us not only for a livelihood, but for the fulfilment of one's *svadharma*.

¹ Commonly attributed to the *Viṣṇu Purāṇa* (1.19.41) and widely cited in the Indian educational tradition.

It is this understanding of education as the cultivation of the whole human being through the discovery of one's *svadharma* that finds one of its most complete expressions in Sage Bharata's *Nāṭyaśāstra*².

Creators, Not Applicants

Every graduate begins as an applicant. The deeper purpose of education, however, is not to leave individuals permanently dependent upon opportunities created by others, but to enable them gradually to become creators of enterprises, institutions, knowledge, artistic expression and social innovation.

An educational system organised primarily around employability asks how young people may be fitted into existing structures. One organised around liberation asks how individuals may discover their *svadharma* and enlarge society's capacity to create value.

The difference is profound. Applicants wait for opportunities to be distributed. Creators expand the field of opportunity itself. Applicants remain dependent upon gatekeepers who control access to livelihood. Creators progressively reduce that dependence by generating new possibilities for themselves and for others. Whether they become entrepreneurs, scientists, engineers, artists, educators, public servants or social innovators, they enlarge not only economic opportunity but also cultural, scientific and civic possibility.

None of this diminishes the importance of examinations, universities or public employment. Nor does it lessen the urgency of procedural reform. Honest examinations and transparent recruitment remain indispensable to a constitutional democracy. They are simply not the whole of education.

Every graduate may begin professional life as a *karmachārī*, conscientiously discharging assigned responsibilities. The deeper purpose of education, however, is to help individuals evolve into *karmayogīs*, whose work is animated not merely by obligation, but by purpose, self-mastery and service. Such individuals do not simply seek employment or advancement; they elevate work into a form of contribution.

Procedural justice ultimately rests upon moral formation. Institutions can regulate conduct only to a point; beyond that point they depend upon citizens whose integrity arises not from surveillance but from character. Rules become effective only when people understand the purposes they serve.

Education that liberates therefore performs a constitutional function. It cultivates self-governing citizens capable not merely of sustaining institutions, but of renewing them. The strength of a republic ultimately depends not upon the sophistication of its

² The *Nāṭyaśāstra*, traditionally attributed to Sage Bharata, is India's foundational treatise on theatre, dance, music, aesthetics and performance. Beyond the performing arts, it presents a comprehensive vision of human formation through disciplined practice, ethical refinement and aesthetic experience.

examinations, but upon the quality of the human beings its education helps to form.

A Civilisational Opportunity

The young people leading today's protests have already rendered an important public service by compelling the nation to confront the fragility of its institutions. Their demand for procedural integrity deserves unequivocal support. Yet this moment also presents a deeper opportunity. Having rightly asked for fair examinations, students may now ask a more fundamental question:

What kind of human beings should education help us become?

That question shifts the conversation from administration to civilisation. A society may refine the machinery through which opportunities are distributed, or it may cultivate citizens capable of creating new opportunities through knowledge, enterprise, artistic excellence and public service. The former improves systems. The latter renews society.

It is precisely this understanding of education, not merely as preparation for employment but as the formation of the whole person, that finds one of its most compelling expressions in Sage Bharata's *Nāṭyaśāstra*. Long regarded as a treatise on drama and dance, it is, in a deeper sense, a profound work on education, character formation and the cultivation of human flourishing.



From Reflection to Sāadhanā: A Nāṭyaśāstra Epilogue



The questions raised by India's present educational challenge extend far beyond schools, universities and examination systems. They invite us to revisit a deeper civilisational question: What is education ultimately meant to cultivate? In this regard, the *Nāṭyaśāstra* offers an unexpectedly profound perspective.

Although often described as a treatise on drama, dance and performance, the *Nāṭyaśāstra* is fundamentally concerned with integrated human development and the ordering of society through aesthetic experience. Sage Bharata presents *Nāṭya* not merely as artistic accomplishment, but as a public discipline that refines perception, awakens moral imagination and contributes to social harmony. Its purpose is succinctly expressed in the celebrated verse:

धर्म्यं यशस्यमायुष्यं हितं बुद्धिविवर्धनम् ।
लोकोपदेशजननं नाट्यमेतद्भविष्यति ॥³

Nāṭya shall promote Dharma, confer honour and well-being, enlarge the intellect, and serve as an instrument for the instruction and uplift of society.

If education is the cultivation of the person, then *Nāṭya* is one of its most refined disciplines. Sage Bharata's vision reminds us that knowledge reaches its fulfilment not in certification, but in the cultivation of wisdom, discernment and the capacity to contribute meaningfully to the flourishing of society.

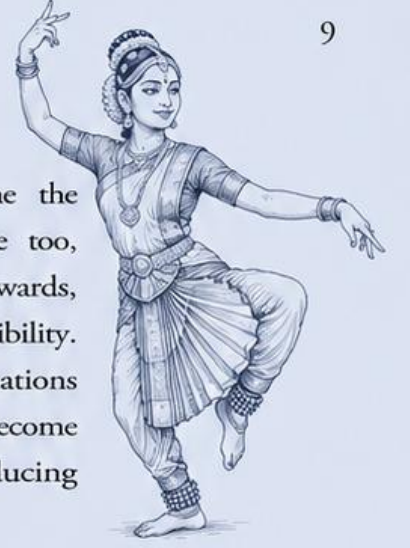
For the practitioner of *Nāṭya*, this insight has profound implications. Daily *sāadhanā* is not merely technical rehearsal; it is a process of self-formation. Through sustained practice, the body becomes an instrument of expression, the mind acquires steadiness, the emotions are refined, and the imagination is disciplined. Technique is never an end in itself. It is the means through which the practitioner gradually discovers and embodies *svadharma*.

In this sense, the artistic journey mirrors the educational journey itself. Every student begins with imitation. Under the guidance of the *Guru*, imitation matures into understanding, understanding into discernment, and discernment into authentic expression. The goal is not to produce replicas of a tradition, but practitioners whose originality arises from deep fidelity to it. Just as education should enable applicants to become creators, *Nāṭya* should enable performers to become creators of aesthetic, cultural and civilisational value.

³ Bharata Muni, *Nāṭyaśāstra*, Chapter 1, Verse 115.



This perspective also invites artists to examine the assumptions governing their own practice. Here too, success is often measured by performances, awards, institutional affiliations, certifications or digital visibility. These have their legitimate place, just as examinations have their place within education. Yet when they become the primary measure of achievement, they risk reducing art to another credentialing system.



The *Nāṭyaśāstra* invites practitioners to remember a higher standard. The deeper question is not merely, 'How well did I perform?' but 'What has my practice formed within me?' Has it refined perception? Has it cultivated humility and discernment? Has it enlarged my capacity for compassion, *paropakāra* (selfless service) and creative responsibility? Has it enabled me to contribute more fully to *dharma*, peace and the flourishing of society?

Perhaps the most enduring lesson of Sage Bharata's vision is that every performance educates. Through *rasa*, the artist shapes imagination, refines emotional life and participates in the ethical formation of society. The practitioner is therefore more than a performer. She becomes a custodian of public consciousness, entrusted with sustaining the aesthetic and moral imagination upon which a flourishing civilisation depends.

If these reflections are to contribute meaningfully to educational renewal, they must find expression not only in individual lives but also in institutions. For *Nāṭyaśāstra Gurukulam*, this is the movement from reflection to *sādhana*. Our endeavour is to cultivate practitioners who are not merely accomplished performers, but thoughtful educators, creators, scholars and institution-builders. We seek to unite scholarship with practice, aesthetic excellence with ethical responsibility, and artistic discipline with public life, affirming that the wisdom of the *Nāṭyaśāstra* belongs not only on the stage but also in contemporary conversations on education, leadership, governance and the cultivation of a society characterised by peace, prosperity and civilisational renewal.

In the spirit of सा विद्या या विमुक्तये *Nāṭyaśāstra Gurukulam* is committed to contributing, through research, education and *sādhana*, to the formation of individuals whose knowledge matures into wisdom, whose skill matures into service, and whose personal excellence becomes a source of collective flourishing.

The movement from reflection to *sādhana* is not only the path of the artist. It is an enduring pathway towards the renewal of education, institutions and civilisation itself.